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THE TEST BOOK

38 TOOLS TO LEAD YOU TO SUCCESS

Translated by Jenny Piening and Rachel Farmer



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INSTRUCTIONS FOR USE

Never before have humans had to undergo as many tests as we do today. There's a test before it all starts (a pregnancy test) and one when it's all over (to determine the cause of death). And in between? From the cradle to the grave, from head to toe, we're subjected to a barrage of evaluations, standardisations and formulae: prenatal diagnostics, GCSEs, driving test, army physical, IQ, EQ, fitness test, depression test, dementia test – life is one long test, and we are just the candidates.

This book satisfies all your testing needs, compiling 38 tests – famous and obscure ones, historical and brand-new ones – that interpret your life.

A test is a measurement method. A basic distinction can be made between binary, quantitative and qualitative tests. Binary tests divide results into two categories: positive/negative, right/wrong, pregnant/not pregnant. Quantitative tests locate your result on a scale and compare it with other people's results, for example IQ tests or sport tests. Qualitative tests produce descriptive, typological results, for example, the Ayurveda Test. But tests are also powerful instruments. They decide who belongs and who doesn't. They draw the line between normal and crazy, between us and others, between below and above average.

You can open this book at any page and dip in and out as you please. Test yourself, your friends, colleagues or family members. *The Test Book* is written for anyone who is curious. Because tests don't only serve the purpose of

compartmentalising, they also provide orientation. Who am I? What can I do? Where do I stand in comparison to others? Only when you know where you stand can you find out where you want to go.

If you are more practically minded and want to start by evaluating your own life, then go straight to the first test on page 14. Or if you want to start with a brief overview and learn about the very first test in human history, begin on the next page, where we give you 'A brief history of the test'.

A BRIEF HISTORY OF THE TEST

Tests are as old as humanity, and there are four fundamental questions that we have never stopped asking: 'Are you guilty?', 'Are you able?', 'Who am I?' and 'Am I healthy?'.

We all know the guilt question from the Bible. In the guise of a wily snake, God tested whether Adam and Eve could resist the temptation of the apple. They couldn't. In the Book of Numbers we find the famous infidelity test: a wife whose husband suspects her of adultery is made to drink a potion of bitter water. Her 'belly swelling and thigh falling' was proof of her guilt.

A psychologically convincing lie test can be traced back to early India. The suspected liar is led into a dark tent. Inside there is a donkey, whose tail has been coated in lamp oil. The man is told to pull on the donkey's tail. If he is a liar, the man is told, pulling the donkey's tail will cause it to scream, because it is clairvoyant. The man is left alone with the animal and after a while is brought back out of the tent. It doesn't matter if the donkey screamed or not, the evidence is on the man's hands. If they are clean it proves his guilt because he didn't touch the donkey's tail, and according to the inventors of this test, you can tell a liar by his fear of being found out. Modern lie detector tests are based on the same principle.

Divine judgement

The first documented test in human history also dealt with the question of guilt. Divine judgement was a well-known method for establishing guilt in ancient China, India and

Asia Minor. To establish the accused person's guilt, he had to 'go before God'. One of the oldest written records, the Code of Ur-Nammu (2100 BC), describes such divine judgments. For example, in the 'ordeal by water' the accused was thrown into water; if he drowned, he was guilty. This method continued to be used for thousands of years, albeit in many variations. In the witch trials of the Middle Ages in Europe, for example, the 'trial by water' was interpreted the other way round. If the woman didn't drown, she was guilty; if she did drown, she was innocent (but unfortunately dead).

Initiation and assessment

'Are you guilty?' is the first question that tests have dealt with since time immemorial. The second is 'Are you able?' We know from early documentation of initiation rites, trials of courage, and inauguration ceremonies that joining a community often involved passing a test. Before being accepted into a group, the aspirants, or novices, first had to prove themselves to the community. This goes for religious communities and fraternities, indigenous tribes and street gangs. The only difference is the rituals themselves – and these vary greatly.

In the United States, if you want to join one of the powerful frats (fraternities) that exist at many universities, you have to go through a 'hazing' ritual, an unofficial admission test. At one frat in Dartmouth College, for example, candidates have to eat a 'vomelet' (an omelette made of vomit). Elsewhere in the United States, those who want to join the white supremacist prison gang the Aryan Brotherhood have to kill a fellow prison inmate. After being circumcised, Maasai boys have to set up a camp deep in the bush and live there for ten years with other freshly circumcised boys before

returning to the community. And those who want a Christian baptism as an adult have first to spend a year proving their faith.

The idea of judging humans based on merit rather than heritage originated in China. Around AD 600, the Sui dynasty established the *keju*, or imperial examinations, for recruiting bureaucrats – a mixture of army physical, rote learning and little puzzles. For example, in the final exam, candidates had to drink strong liquor and then compose a poem – which isn't hard to imagine as a creative exercise in some modern assessment centres.

The psychotechnicians

In the western world, the idea that a young person would choose a career based on a job-oriented test rather than on family tradition or personal inclination, is a relatively new phenomenon. It started at the beginning of the 20th century and was inspired by machine efficiency testing. The US mechanical engineer Frederick Winslow Taylor searched for the optimal working process that eliminated every imprecision, every inefficiency, every unnecessary motion (hence the term 'Taylorism'). Because it worked so well with machines, in the 1920s the 'psychotechnician' asked himself: why not do the same with humans? It was assumed that particular skills were necessary for particular working processes, but that these could not be learned. Instead, they were ascertained in an aptitude test, the results of which allocated candidates a particular job.

The 900-page standard reference work *Handbuch Psychotechnischer Eignungsprüfungen (Handbook of Psychotechnical Aptitude Tests)* by Fritz Giese reveals the breadth of these kinds of tests. The job aptitudes range from 'female

hand coordination skills' to the 'suitcase test', in which you had to pack a case with clothes and 'unwieldy objects'.

In the mid-1950s such aptitude tests were replaced by the kind of testing we are familiar with today. Nowadays, a person is hired not because they can prove that they are able to carry out a particular work process, but because they are the 'best person' for the job.

Modern oracles

The third big test question is 'Who am I?' When you were at your wits' end in ancient Greece, you would consult an oracle. The most famous and popular oracle was the one in Delphi – despite or because of the fact that, instead of giving clear answers, it would recite enigmatic verses that usually only made sense once the future had come to pass.

Over the entrance to the temple of Delphi where the oracle lived, there was an inscription: *Gnothi seauton* ('Know thyself').

This maxim is important. It is the leitmotif running through all attempts to measure a person's soul, personality and temperament. The entire history of tests can be seen as an attempt to give scientific credence to the ancient oracle.

The first attempts at describing a person based on their personality (and not on their physical features or heritage) were made in ancient Greece. The result was the four temperaments: choleric, melancholic, phlegmatic and sanguine (Temperament Test, p. 14).

It would be another 2,000 years until the next serious attempt was made to quantify the personality of a human being. The

Swiss pastor Johann Kaspar Lavater developed an idea already suggested by Aristotle, that it was possible to judge a person's character and intelligence based on hair colour, brain size, bone structure or nose shape. Physiognomy enjoyed its heyday in the 19th and early 20th centuries and served as a basis for eugenics and racist ideology.

These kinds of interpretations were countered by Sigmund Freud's exploration of the psyche. According to his revolutionary theory, our personality is not just innate but is also shaped by our culture. In 1921, Freud's former pupil Carl Gustav Jung published his work *Psychological Types*, triggering a wave of personality classifications that are still used today. In his book, Jung defined two elements of personality structure: introversion and extroversion. People show their true selves in their behaviour towards the outside world: extroverts turn their gaze outwards, introverts focus inwards.

Jung went into further detail on these two types, ascribing them four 'functions': thinking, feeling, sensing and intuition. From these arose various character types within a matrix, which Jung compared with historical figures. For example, Goethe was 'extrovert and intuitive', somebody 'who always sees new possibilities and who in his eternal striving for change tears down what he has only just built'. However, Jung was aware of the limitations of such sketchy classifications and stated in his writing that the true complexity of a person can never be fully described.

Who am I? And how good am I?

Personality classifications were originally conceived as clinical instruments, but by the mid-20th century, human resources had discovered the possibilities of using typologies during the recruitment process.

One example of this is the scientifically controversial yet still widely used Myers-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI)®. This test judges a person in the Jungian tradition according to how they present themselves to the outside world. This involves questions such as: Are you more of a practical or effusive person? Is it more important for you to stick to your principles or to listen to your feelings? It is usually easy to answer spontaneously, but if you take time to think about it, you will generally come to the conclusion that the only real answer is 'It depends'. Because in some situations you might be goal-oriented and pragmatic, in others dreamy or distracted. Which brings us to one of the most frequent criticisms of such methods: their binary nature. You have to be either introverted *or* extroverted, thinking *or* feeling. There are no grey areas and therefore no ambivalence.

And yet it would be a mistake to write off these kinds of tests completely. The writer Malcolm Gladwell showed how they are both banal *and* very clever. As a student, he and a friend developed their own test on a whim, inventing different personality types:

1. In a romantic relationship are you more canine or feline? In other words: 'Are you the pursuer, who runs happily to the door, tail wagging? Or are you the pursued?'

2. Do you need more information or lots of different information? In other words: 'Is it your intellectual style to gather and master as much information as you can or to make imaginative use of a discrete amount of information?'

3. Are you an insider or an outsider? In other words: 'Do you get along with your parents or do you define yourself outside your relationship with your mother and father?'

4. Are you a nibbler or a gobbler? In other words: 'Do you

work steadily, in small increments, or do everything at once, in a big gulp?’

The four questions cover the areas of relationships, cognition, family and work habits. The test is of course nonsense. Yet you immediately recognise yourself – and others.

In modern psychology, the ‘Big Five’ model is the standard means of categorising personality types (Big Five Test, p. 24). This test is also criticised for asking too little with too many questions. However, at least its five personality types are not exclusively binary, but scaled. You are both one thing and another, not one *or* the other.

The screw-up that I am

Modern personality tests reveal an important shift in testing: aptitude tests or psychological assessments were prescribed by the powers that be, but nowadays we usually carry out personality and performance tests off our own bat. The willingness with which we evaluate our talent, our work–life balance, our sex life, our spiritual potential or our risk tolerance using tests, questionnaires and checklists on the internet, in magazines or in books like this one, is not only an expression of the old longing to know oneself. More than that, it points to our deep-rooted insecurity. Could I have done better in life? To take it to the extreme, you could say that the question ‘Who am I?’ has been replaced with the self-optimising question ‘Am I good enough?’ We assess ourselves and compare ourselves with others; we conceal our weaknesses and emphasise our strengths.

At their core, most tests are about inferring future performance, risks, intentions or possibilities from the past (career,

medical history, buying behaviour), from the present (abilities and personality) and from comparisons with others (norm group, target group, circle of friends). It is this 'prognostic validity', i.e. the promise of an alleged predictability of events, which makes tests so attractive.

The future of the test

Our obsession with analysing ourselves is not just restricted to our personalities or careers, but is also increasingly extending to our physical performance. Self-tracking, i.e. recording every kind of personal data imaginable – from calorie consumption to blood pressure to the number of steps we take a day – is an indication of how we have come to concentrate obsessively on ourselves. The writer Juli Zeh wrote that biocentric is egocentric. The human is nothing more than a constantly self-evaluating and judging candidate; the norm that we compare ourselves to is our friends on social media. At the same time, self-tracking apps represent a shift towards the fourth big test question: 'Am I healthy?' The decisive question is no longer 'How good am I?' but 'How am I?' Of course, health has always been an important issue, as we know from the ancient Egyptian 'Edwin Smith Papyrus' (c.1500 BC), probably the world's first medical text. Historically, knowing if you were healthy or ill was a question that could only be answered by experts. Today, apps facilitate self-diagnosis.

The next generation of self-tracking apps not only collates specific values, but also analyses our metadata: where am I, with whom, since when, for how long? Our every movement, what we eat and drink, our feelings and reactions, are measured, compared and evaluated. And one day, apps will also be able to tell us what we have gained – financially, emotionally and in terms of our health – from our contacts, jobs and

activities. Some people believe that ‘life tracking’ is just a step behind gene tracking. But we don’t just test ourselves and our offspring; we are constantly passing judgement on everything and everyone around us: a professor’s lecture, the book we bought on Amazon, the service in the hotel, the advice of a financial advisor, the candidates on a talent show, our friends’ social media posts. And we immediately publish our ‘score’ in the form of online comments. We live in a data dictatorship; our ideology is measurability. And tests are the oracles of the modern world.

Personality & character

1

—

AM I CHOLERIC?

When it comes down to it, people care about two things: understanding themselves and being understood by others. We strive for self-awareness and long for people to see us as we really are.

The first person to try to explain ‘who we really are’ was the philosopher Empedocles (490–430 BC). He compared the temperaments of different people with the characteristics of the four elements – fire, water, earth and air. Some people are hot-headed like fire, others as gentle as water. The four elements also corresponded to particular gods: Earth (Hera) is phlegmatic but constant, water (Persephone) gentle but deep, air (Hermes) exuberant but volatile, and fire (Zeus) determined but bad-tempered. Galen of Pergamon linked this approach to Hippocrates’ humoral pathology and coined the terms phlegmatic, melancholic, sanguine and choleric.

The four designations are still in common use today, and although it is hard to pin down their precise meaning, we can usually intuitively find an example of each among our colleagues. The choleric, whose fire flares up and abates without providing warmth; the sanguine one, who is vivacious but jumps erratically from one thing to another; the melancholic, who is a burden to himself; and the phlegmatic, who is a burden to others.

Seen in the light of modern psychology, the four temperaments and their hybrid forms have become obsolete. And yet they form the historic foundation for the way in which we define human characteristics, and are deeply rooted in popular culture.



Your temperament comes to the fore when you feel like you have been treated unfairly. Your character is revealed in the way you treat people from whom you have nothing to gain.

**TO WHAT EXTENT DO THE FOLLOWING STATEMENTS
APPLY TO YOU?**

Doesn't apply to
me at all

1

2

3

4

5

Completely applies
to me

-
- ☐ 1. You are bursting with childish energy and optimism, and you like to gesticulate when you speak.
- ☐ 2. You wear your heart on your sleeve and never hide your feelings. In an animated conversation you have no problem gripping or touching the other person's arm.
- ☐ 3. You have a knack for storytelling and others enjoy listening to you. You inspire others and make them laugh.
- ☐ 4. You find it easy to win people over with your charm and wit, and you rarely need facts to do so.
- ☐ 5. In conversation you are more of a talker than a listener. What you want to say is so important to you that you sometimes interrupt the person you are talking to.
- ☐ 6. From one minute to the next, your mood can change from elated to gloomy.
- ☐ 7. You are overhasty, easily distracted and quick to get bored. You find it hard to develop routines and rhythms, although you know it would be good for you.
- ☐ 8. You want to feel loved and need to be popular and applauded. You allow a lot, and do everything, to be liked.

- 9. You prefer to make a plan and to follow it. You are better at developing and making a plan than carrying it out.
- 10. You are methodical, organised and tidy. You like detailed work. Maths, research, controlling expenditure, handicrafts and graphic design are areas in which you might feel at home.
- 11. You are quick to recognise the feelings and needs of others. You are in tune with your own and others' feelings.
- 12. You have an intense, deep personality. You are prone to introspection and enjoy deep conversations with one other person. You hate superficial chit-chat.
- 13. It is hard to please you. You bear grudges.
- 14. You try and see the good side of things and to stay positive, but quickly see the difficult side of a situation.
- 15. You often withdraw and need a lot of time to yourself. You are happy with your own company.
- 16. Wherever you are, whatever you're doing, you are constantly analysing and judging situations, other people and yourself.
- 17. 'I agree!' is a sentence that you often come out with. You rarely feel the need to assert yourself or your opinions. You are adaptable.
- 18. You are tactful, sensitive and polite with others.
- 19. You are balanced, calm and collected. You are unperturbed by delays and hectic situations. You are patient, easy-going and tolerant.

- ☐ 20. You have a dry sense of humour, which is expressed in sarcastic comments but always with a twinkle in your eye.
- ☐ 21. You find it hard to make decisions.
- ☐ 22. You are laid-back and rarely swept away by anything. You measure activities with the equation 'gain divided by effort'.
- ☐ 23. You are often unsure, worry, and mull over problems alone.
- ☐ 24. You avoid conflict. Anger and frustration eat into you.
- ☐ 25. You love a challenge. You see it as an opportunity to show what you're capable of. You turn every situation into a competition.
- ☐ 26. You are assertive and sure of yourself. People think twice before speaking out against you.
- ☐ 27. You don't care what other people think of you or your ideas, you are confident of your own abilities.
- ☐ 28. You are decisive. In almost all situations you act quickly and efficiently.
- ☐ 29. You are impatient with others. You react over-hastily, irritably and impetuously. You are bad at accepting other points of view or ways of working.
- ☐ 30. You find it difficult to show feelings and affection.
- ☐ 31. Your persistence can quickly turn to stubbornness.
- ☐ 32. You are a workaholic. You are spurred on by the fact that you feel unhappy or even worthless if you are not constantly doing or achieving something.

Add up your points and insert them in the table below.

Which type is most pronounced for you? For which type did you get the lowest score? Ask someone who knows you well to fill out the table for you.

	Statements 1-8	Statements 9-16	Statements 17-24	Statements 25-32
TYPE	sanguine	melancholic	phlegmatic	choleric
My points				
Friend's evaluation				

2

—

AM I CRAZY?

It is the genesis of psychology: a trustworthy elderly man pushes a rectangular piece of blotting paper across his desk to you. On the paper is an inkblot. 'What could it be?' he asks you.

For a long time, the famous Rorschach inkblot test was regarded as an 'X-ray of the soul', as a key to the subconscious. Messages from the subconscious were read into the patient's interpretations, which were then pseudo-scientifically analysed using algorithms.

The Rorschach test, named after the Swiss psychiatrist Hermann Rorschach, was based on a party game that Rorschach loved to play as a child. You make an inkblot on a piece of paper, which you then fold down the middle so that when you open it up you have a completely symmetric image. Each player then describes what he or she can see. A butterfly? A giraffe with wings? Or perhaps even female genitalia? Rorschach started turning the game into an analytical method. According to Rorschach, when subjects were confronted with an ambiguous picture, it elicited free associations with their memories and suppressed emotions, enabling an interpretation of the subject's personality structure. In 1921 he published the ten original ink pictures, which are the ones still used today.

Because different psychiatrists interpreted the same

answer differently, the method fell into disrepute in the 1950s. To give it credibility again, the US psychologist John Ernest Exner began to compile norm values out of thousands of Rorschach protocols. Thanks to the Exner Scoring System the test is approved in various countries including the United States, Brazil and Japan. In Europe, it is only occasionally used in forensics, and sometimes as a tool for personnel assessment, for example to find out how a job applicant reacts to an unusual or unexpected situation.

Although attitudes to the inkblot test differ widely, it remains the third constant in the ancestral gallery of psychology next to Freud's couch and Pavlov's dog.



You want to be 'average' when you do this test. Don't try to impress with creative answers. Genitals, blood and childhood memories will naturally awaken the psychiatrist's interest (which you may be trying to avoid ...). If in doubt, say it as it is: I see an inkblot.

WHAT COULD IT BE?





The vast majority of people see a bat, a moth or a butterfly.

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